

Chapter 154-1

"Who fell into the water?"

"I don't know, I didn't see."

"Why are so many people going in?"

"Is it some important person?"

"..."

Soon the poolside was surrounded by people. The little girl in the pink princess dress stood there at a loss, watching the water splashing continuously in the pool, and suddenly burst into loud sobs.

Someone recognized the little girl and hurriedly asked: "Sisi, where's your mommy?"

Only then did the host of this banquet, Qin Liushuang, appear in everyone's sight.

Following that, two pairs of figures emerged from the water almost simultaneously.

Lu Jiayi was supporting the already unconscious Xu Qingzhu.

Zhao Xuning was holding onto Liang Shi.

The pool wasn't particularly deep, but it was still two meters.

Just the right height where one couldn't stand.

The moment she emerged from the water, Liang Shi swam toward Xu Qingzhu. Almost at the same time Lu Jiayi brought Xu Qingzhu to shore, Liang Shi arrived at her side.

Xu Qingzhu's face was pale, her eyes tightly closed, and her hair and makeup that had just been done that evening were all in disarray.

Zhao Xuning leaped out of the water in one motion, and without caring that she was still dripping wet, hurriedly began administering first aid to Xu Qingzhu.

Soon, Xu Qingzhu spat out a mouthful of water, her fingers curling slightly.

In her dazed state, her hand fell on the back of Liang Shi's hand, lightly patting it twice without much strength, signaling her to be at ease.

The heart that Liang Shi had been holding in suspense seemed to find its anchor in that instant.

Sun Chengcheng immediately handed over towels and hot water. Lu Jiayi, half-crouching to the side, only calmly observed these people, watching the scene before her with near indifference.

Faced with the towel Sun Chengcheng offered, she didn't take it. She tossed her still-dripping long hair to one side and lightly wrung it with her hand, as composed as if she had just taken a bath.

Fortunately, with Zhao Xuning there, Xu Qingzhu quickly woke up.

She looked at Liang Shi thoughtfully, then turned to look at Lu Jiayi, nodding slightly to express her thanks.

Lu Jiayi stood up: "It's nothing."

Then she got up and left, leaving only her solitary retreating figure for everyone to see.

After falling into the water, Xu Qingzhu felt completely drained of strength, and her head was still a bit dizzy.

She kept leaning against Liang Shi.

Since the incident was caused by that little girl, Qin Liushuang suggested having a server take her to the lounge.

"We've specially prepared a lounge and spare clothing for our guests. You and your wife can go change." After Qin Liushuang finished speaking, she glanced at Zhao Xuning. "Miss Zhao, I'll have someone take you to another lounge."

Zhao Xuning, with her cleanliness obsession, furrowed her brows tightly and suppressed her agitation: "Thank you for the trouble."

As she was leaving, she passed by Liang Shi and whispered a reminder: "Stay close to Xu Qingzhu. Someone is targeting you two."

Liang Shi nodded. She had long noticed that Xu Qingzhu had put all her body weight on her.

Xu Qingzhu lowered her eyelashes, looking extremely weak.

Su Zhe, Liang Xinzhou, and the others had already come over. After supporting Xu Qingzhu for a few steps, Liang Shi felt that Xu Qingzhu truly didn't even have the strength to walk. Without caring what anyone present thought, she directly lifted her up in a princess carry.

Xu Qingzhu's blue gauze dress was like a mermaid's tail, gently draping over Liang Shi's arms.

Her slender back pressed tightly against Liang Shi's forearm, and even the position of her shoulder blades could be felt clearly.

Along with her weak heartbeat.

While she still had a sliver of consciousness, Xu Qingzhu slightly turned her face and buried herself entirely in Liang Shi's embrace.

Through the crowd, they walked as if no one else existed.

Chapter 154-2

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Second floor lounge.

Qin Lishuang drained the last drop of wine from her glass and casually tossed the transparent, clear glass into the trash bin.

Glass and metal collided, making a "clang" sound.

The corners of her eyes and lips were both turned upward, carrying a hint of wickedness.

"Miss." A man in a black tailcoat said respectfully from behind her, "Everything has been arranged."

"Mm." Qin Lishuang asked, "Where's Sisi?"

The man paused briefly: "She went to the lounge with the Second Miss."

"Got it." Qin Lishuang lowered her brows and eyes. "Then I'll go see my prey."

Her right index finger curled slightly. Those who knew her well knew this was her signature gesture when she started getting excited.

The server obediently stepped aside to make way.

Qin Lishuang strode forward with large steps. When she reached the door, her footsteps paused slightly. "If Second Sister asks, just say I'm not feeling well and left early."

Server: "Yes."

But unexpectedly, the moment Qin Lishuang stepped out the door, she ran into Lu Jiayi who was soaking wet. Her expression changed slightly.

"Miss Lu." Qin Lishuang's tone was unfriendly. "Since when have you become so kind-hearted?"

Lu Jiayi frowned slightly. "This is the Qin family's banquet."

Qin Lishuang sneered. "Oh, so you do know this is the Qin family's banquet?"

In other words—what does it have to do with you, someone surnamed Lu?

Lu Jiayi naturally caught the implication in her words and said coldly: "Do you know what you're doing?"

"No need for Miss Lu to worry." Qin Lishuang said, "Since you're soaked through, you should go change your clothes. Stop always meddling in other people's business."

Lu Jiayi: "..."

"What you're doing will create a crisis for the Qin family." Lu Jiayi said sternly, "The Qin family is already hanging in the balance right now. Do you really want to push the Qin family into the abyss?"

"What does that have to do with me?" Qin Lishuang looked over frivolously. "Whatever happens to the Qin family, happens."

"You're also surnamed Qin." Lu Jiayi said.

Qin Lishuang raised an eyebrow. "That's really funny."

As she spoke, she burst into unrestrained laughter. Only after she had laughed enough did she raise her hand to wipe the tears from the corners of her eyes. "Miss Lu, this is the funniest joke I've heard in my thirty-some years of life."

Lu Jiayi's brows knitted tightly together, her gaze becoming increasingly sharp.

But Qin Lishuang remained unmoved. "Forget it. Seeing as you're still a child, let me teach you something."

"If you don't know another's suffering—don't advise them to be good¹. Just like those dirty matters you encountered in the Lu family, who would know once you walk out? But you still carry the surname Lu." Qin Lishuang scoffed lightly, "But Qin Lishuang can carry any surname—except she refuses to be surnamed Qin."

After saying that, she walked around Lu Jiayi and left.

Lu Jiayi stared at her retreating figure until she disappeared.

The feeling Qin Lishuang gave her was more like—she couldn't wait for the Qin family to disappear from this world.

Lu Jiayi returned to the lounge. While changing her clothes, she was still thinking—if it weren't for the marriage alliance between the Lu family and the Qin family, she couldn't be bothered to deal with this mess.

Everyone in this circle knew that when one pillar fell, out of three people crushed to death, two of them would inevitably be relatives by marriage.

Judging from the situation just now, those two people were certainly not nobodies.

With Qin Lishuang causing such a scene, something big was bound to happen.

The Lu family still wanted to borrow the Qin family's influence. If Qin Lishuang ended up tearing the Qin family apart, the Lu family might have to divert resources to deal with it.

But the current Lu family was caught up in endless internal strife and simply couldn't spare the resources.

If resources had to be diverted, it would inevitably fall on her.

After all, having been looked after more by her younger aunt since childhood, she had to protect the Qin family.

Lu Jiayi changed her clothes and ran out without even having time to dry her hair.

She had to stop Qin Lishuang.

Footnotes:

¹ "If you don't know another's suffering—don't advise them to be good" (不知他人苦——莫勸他人善): A Chinese saying meaning that one shouldn't lecture others about morality or proper behavior when you don't understand the hardships and circumstances they've been through. It's a reminder not to judge others without knowing their full story.

Chapter 154-3

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Liang Shi carried Xu Qingzhu to the lounge. After entering, only the two of them remained.

Xu Qingzhu had fallen into the water once, and all the water in her abdominal cavity had clearly been expelled. By rights, she should have been lively and energetic, but she felt particularly listless.

Liang Shi asked her softly, "Are you okay?"

Xu Qingzhu felt like something was pressing down on her head when she spoke, and frowned: "Not really."

"Do you want to go to the hospital?" Liang Shi asked. "Or should I get Zhao Xuning to come take a look?"

"Change clothes first." Xu Qingzhu said weakly.

She licked her lips, her arms propped against the edge of the bed. Seeing Liang Shi half-crouching in front of her with a worried expression, she raised her hand to brush aside Liang Shi's soaking wet hair ends.

"Jiejie." Xu Qingzhu's voice was very low. "Now I've fallen into water."

Liang Shi was stunned for a moment upon hearing this, then smiled bitterly with helplessness. "Yes, you've fallen into water."

Seeing how difficult it was for Xu Qingzhu to speak, Liang Shi supported her upper body. "Don't talk for now. I'll help you change."

Xu Qingzhu nodded.

The Qin family had prepared two sets of casual clothes, brand new with the tags still attached.

This kind of backup was usually prepared at evening banquets, just in case situations like this occurred.

Liang Shi picked up the clothes and cut off the tags, then looked at Xu Qingzhu.

Perhaps because they hadn't seen each other for so long, and they weren't at their own home.

Reaching out to undress Xu Qingzhu felt a bit strange.

Liang Shi gave a soft cough. "I'm going to take it off now."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She chuckled lightly and stretched out her weak hand to kick Liang Shi's calf. "Stop being annoying."

Liang Shi reached behind her, her hand trembling slightly as she pulled down the zipper. "I'm afraid you'll be shy."

"Hurry up." Xu Qingzhu urged her.

As Liang Shi's hand moved down, Xu Qingzhu's dress fell away.

The Qin family had been thoughtful—even the underwear was a complete new set.

Xu Qingzhu really had no strength left. Even trying to prop her arms at her sides, she couldn't support her upper body, so she had to lie down again.

Her wet long hair spread across the white pillow. Sinking into the soft bed made her extremely drowsy.

The strange sensations from her body were all too obvious.

While Liang Shi was helping her change, she suddenly said: "There was something in the wine Qin Lishuang gave."

Liang Shi's movements paused. "But you took it from a passing server."

At the time, Liang Shi had thought to herself, as expected of Xu Qingzhu, someone who had seen the world.

Whether going to a bar or attending an evening banquet, the default assumption was that after leaving your original spot, you wouldn't drink the wine that had been at your previous position when you returned.

The fear was precisely that someone might have slipped something into it.

So Xu Qingzhu's approach at the time had been the most appropriate.

"But you forgot." Xu Qingzhu's hand gripped the bedsheet, trying to regain some strength, but she couldn't even manage to keep talking. "This is the Qin family's territory."

Liang Shi: "..."

"So you think Qin Lishuang bribed the server?" Liang Shi asked.

"Perhaps she didn't even need to bribe them." Xu Qingzhu said. "Also, that little girl earlier—I felt like she pushed me."

Because it was a little girl about the same age as Sheng Yu, Xu Qingzhu had been completely off guard.

But at that moment, she had indeed felt a force.

"But that's Qin Lishuang's daughter." Liang Shi said. "Qin Lishuang and Qin Lishuang have never gotten along."

Just then, Liang Shi finished dressing Xu Qingzhu.

She was about to help blow-dry Xu Qingzhu's hair when Xu Qingzhu looked at her: "Change your clothes first."

"Let me blow-dry your hair." Liang Shi said. "That way if you're sleepy, you can sleep, and I'll carry you out later."

"Change your clothes." Xu Qingzhu insisted stubbornly.

Liang Shi paused for a moment. "Then you're not allowed to fall asleep."

Hearing this, Xu Qingzhu chuckled softly. "Mm."

It was a soft, cute little sound of agreement that came from her breath, sounding milky and sweet, almost melting one's heart.

Liang Shi rubbed the top of her head. "Alright, I'll listen to you."

Xu Qingzhu nodded slightly. "Mm, you can't have seen me while I don't even get to see you."

Saying such a long sentence took some effort, and Xu Qingzhu would pause at certain points. Which made it all the more alluring.

After she finished speaking, Liang Shi's dress happened to fall to the ground.

The light reflected off her skin, so pale it seemed to glow.

Liang Shi's ears suddenly turned bright red. She rubbed her ear. "Stop messing around."

Xu Qingzhu smiled until her eyes curved. "How is this messing around?"

Liang Shi: "..."

Changing her own clothes was much faster than changing Xu Qingzhu's. Liang Shi moved deftly and was done quickly.

After changing, she found Xu Qingzhu staring at her unblinkingly. Liang Shi reached out to cover her eyes with her hand.

Suddenly, a moist sensation came from the back of her hand.

Liang Shi was startled and immediately withdrew her hand, then found herself meeting Xu Qingzhu's gaze directly.

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"What?" Liang Shi feigned composure.

Xu Qingzhu's eyes were moist, full of amusement. "Checking if my tongue is long enough."

Liang Shi: "..."

It was long enough.

Liang Shi reached out to wipe away the moisture she had left behind. "Let's go home."

These words were spoken with tenderness and affection.

Xu Qingzhu nodded.

"You two are so lovey-dovey, I'm almost too embarrassed to come in." With the sound of the door lock turning, the door opened. Qin Lishuang walked in twirling a key in her hand. "I deliberately gave you time to change clothes. Thoughtful enough, right?"

"What do you want?" Liang Shi asked.

Qin Lishuang leaned against the door with her arms crossed. "Little Ah Shi, long time no see."

Liang Shi frowned: "Better if we hadn't met."

"You two are really too vigilant." Qin Lishuang said, "But what can you do? I'm a bit worse than you imagined."

Liang Shi didn't want to waste words with her. "What are you trying to do?"

"What else could I do?" Qin Lishuang pulled out a cigarette from her pocket. "I originally only wanted to find Xu Qingzhu, but then you came too. Doesn't this count as buy one get one free?"

She spoke of them as if they were objects.

"What do you want with me?" Xu Qingzhu spoke coldly. Even though she had no strength in her body, she was still cold and aloof, making people feel she was hard to approach.

"Be my model once." Qin Lishuang lit the cigarette, took a drag, and the bluish-gray smoke dispersed before her eyes. "Then I'll let you both go."

"Qin Lishuang!" Liang Shi shouted at her harshly, her brows and eyes full of ferocity.

As everyone knew, being Qin Lishuang's model meant suffering inhumane treatment.

Thinking of what the original owner had gone through, Liang Shi couldn't help but feel angry.

But Qin Lishuang just smiled: "Little Ah Shi, if you're willing, you can come again too."

"Again?" Xu Qingzhu precisely caught that word in her sentence.

"That's right." Qin Lishuang looked at her frivolously. "To this day, my most satisfying piece of work was provided by little Ah Shi."

No matter what was said, adding a sentence-final particle at the end made it sound suggestive.

But coming from Qin Lishuang, it was simply infuriating.

"But I have a feeling you could surpass little Ah Shi." Qin Lishuang looked at Xu Qingzhu.

"That face of yours is really... I like it so much."

"Bang!"

Before Qin Lishuang could finish speaking, Liang Shi swung a punch at her.

The cigarette was knocked flying, the cigarette butt flickering on and off on the ground.

Qin Lishuang's head hit the door. She was stunned for a moment, then laughed softly: "Long time no see, you're still as violent as ever."

"When I was painting you." Qin Lishuang raised her head, her eyes full of coldness. "Why didn't you react at all?"

Liang Shi swung another punch.

Everything she had learned before seemed to have been preparing for this moment.

Both punches caught Qin Lishuang off guard, but Qin Lishuang showed no reaction. She just stamped out the cigarette butt under her foot and smiled lightly: "What now? Your wife is gone."

Hearing this, Liang Shi turned around. Even the bed where Xu Qingzhu had been placed was gone.

Person and bed had both disappeared from this room.

If you listened carefully, you could still hear the sound of mechanical gears turning.

Liang Shi stepped forward and grabbed her by the throat, shouting harshly: "Where did you take her?"

"That's none of your concern." Qin Lishuang fought back, and the two of them started fighting.

Qin Lishuang usually liked to exercise too. Being punched twice by Liang Shi had already been unexpected.

Now that she was fighting back, she naturally had enough confidence to break free from Liang Shi's grasp.

Although Liang Shi had learned a lot, she didn't have much practical combat experience.

At first she was at a disadvantage, but they were soon evenly matched. The room kept echoing with the sounds of their fighting.

Liang Shi suddenly asked: "Why Xu Qingzhu?"

Qin Lishuang smiled: "Because she's your wife."

As soon as the words fell, Liang Shi's arm was already locked around her neck, and her back slammed against the door with a loud bang.

Qin Lishuang gasped in pain.

Even while being restrained, Qin Lishuang still said: "Little Ah Shi, you really are adorable."

Liang Shi said coldly: "Stop being disgusting."

"Talk." Liang Shi pressed. "Where did you take Xu Qingzhu?"

"To a place no one else knows about, of course." Qin Lishuang said, "But... you know."

"If nothing unexpected happens, she's already left this villa by now." Qin Lishuang smiled lightly, "But what good does it do you to restrain me? There's another lunatic who wants to paint her."

Another lunatic...

"Your lover?" Liang Shi asked back.

Qin Lishuang clicked her tongue: "Why say it so unpleasantly? It's a soulmate."

Liang Shi: "..."

In her memories, that man was an even more disgusting existence than Qin Lishuang.

She would do it with Qin Lishuang in that basement, deliberately letting the original owner watch, just to get that disgusted and revolted expression from the original owner.

That was something the original owner had buried deep in her memories and didn't want to bring up—something Liang Shi had only glimpsed after receiving those memories at the end.

Liang Shi's expression tensed, and in that instant Qin Lishuang broke free. But a moment later, a knife was pointed straight at Qin Lishuang's throat.

The sharp blade instantly grazed across the skin of Qin Lishuang's neck, leaving a blood mark.

Liang Shi pressed closer to her, her voice cold and harsh. "Don't touch Xu Qingzhu."

Liang Shi's voice had already turned hoarse, and she added more force to her hand. Though she only lightly broke the skin, it gave Qin Lishuang the sensation of a dull knife cutting into flesh.

Liang Shi said: "I really will kill you both."

Qin Lishuang shivered.

At this moment, no one would doubt the truth in Liang Shi's words.

Chapter 154-5

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The knife Liang Shi had was taken from the fruit platter in the room while changing clothes earlier, casually tucked into her pocket.

It was meant to guard against Qin Lishuang.

Qin Lishuang said no one else knew, but she knew.

That meant it was the place where Qin Lishuang had kept the original owner before—a villa in the outskirts of the city.

That villa wasn't far from here.

To complete her "art," Qin Lishuang was truly a lunatic through and through.

Reckless and desperate.

Liang Shi asked Zhao Xuning to come to this lounge. Zhao Xuning was surprised: "Didn't you two already leave?"

Liang Shi: "..."

It turned out Zhao Xuning had gone to their lounge to look for them, only to be told that the two had already left.

In reality, it was a lie that Qin Lishuang had the server tell.

At the time, they were in the room next door.

Zhao Xuning acknowledged with an "okay."

The moment she took out her phone, Qin Lishuang sneered again. "You really have gotten a lot smarter."

"On your territory." Liang Shi said, "I have no choice but to be on guard."

After they fell into the water, they hadn't had time to worry about their phones.

Qin Lishuang had also arranged for people to take their phones away.

But Liang Shi had put a backup phone inside the lining of her dress.

Zhao Xuning knocked twice on the door. Coming with her was Zhou Yi'an.

Seeing it was Qin Lishuang, she frowned and said coldly: "Where's Xu Qingzhu?"

Liang Shi put away the knife. Without addressing Zhou Yi'an first, she looked at Zhao Xuning: "Dr. Zhao, did you bring needles?"

Zhao Xuning: "..."

"Then please keep an eye on her." Liang Shi said, "I'm going to find Xu Qingzhu."

Zhao Xuning didn't ask why.

After all, Qin Lishuang's terrible character was known throughout the circle.

Zhou Yi'an only needed one glance to understand what had happened. She asked Liang Shi: "Do you know where?"

Liang Shi nodded: "I should know."

After saying that, she headed out. Zhou Yi'an followed.

"If you're trying to cause trouble, or if you want to get information about the person you like from me." Liang Shi said, "Then you'd better not follow."

Zhou Yi'an's footsteps paused slightly. She said coldly: "She's my superior."

Liang Shi: "..."

"Also." Zhou Yi'an said, "I screwed her over back then. Consider this my compensation to her."

Liang Shi let out a light breath: "Thanks."

Zhou Yi'an was in charge of driving. The car sped along the empty road.

They soon arrived at the destination.

But at the entrance, Liang Shi saw Lu Jiayi. Beside her was Xu Qingzhu, so weak she was about to faint.

Chapter 154-6

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Lu Jiayi originally didn't want to meddle in other people's business either.

But since it involved the Lu family, she couldn't just sit by and watch.

In the end, she still went downstairs, only to see from behind a group of people taking Xu Qingzhu away.

So she followed them all the way here.

The Qin family's people recognized her and even greeted her politely.

But when she asked for the person, those people looked at each other in confusion, as if they only listened to Qin Lishuang.

So Lu Jiayi took action.

As the first heir of the Lu family, surrounded by wolves and tigers¹, dealing with these few people was more than easy.

She hadn't expected that just as she rescued the person, she heard the sound of a sports car.

Lu Jiayi conveniently went with the flow and did a favor.

"Your wife." Lu Jiayi pushed Xu Qingzhu over. "Returned intact."²

Liang Shi looked at Lu Jiayi. She had a faint smile on her face, looking very aloof yet very polite.

Even when supporting Xu Qingzhu when no one else was around, she had used gentleman's hands.

There wasn't much physical contact.

The bodyguards on the ground quickly got up, but Lu Jiayi swept her gaze over them.

"Gentlemen, risking your lives for a bit of money—is it really worth it?"

The bodyguards immediately ceased all resistance, and not one of them dared to step forward.

But Zhou Yi'an loosened up her muscles and bones, cracking her fingers with crisp sounds, and let out a light breath.

Her movements were swift and decisive. She kneed them in the abdomen, and while they were in pain, she grabbed their heads and jabbed her arm against their backs.

As if she had trained countless times, she struck their pressure points with light force, causing those people to break out in cold sweat from the pain, clutching their stomachs and rolling on the ground.

Soon, the commotion outside disturbed the people inside the villa, and the door opened.

A man in a blue bathrobe stood at the door, his hair a mix of black and white. Seeing so many people at the door, he suddenly frowned. "Who are you?"

Hearing this, Liang Shi looked up at him.

He happened to look over at the same time, their eyes meeting.

Liang Shi gritted her teeth with hatred and suddenly said to Zhou Yi'an: "Sister Zhou, this guy is no good. Beat him up and I'll treat you to a meal."

Zhou Yi'an: "?"

Zhou Yi'an looked over with eyes full of confusion, but sneered: "You're treating me like a hired thug?"

Liang Shi: "...I'll treat you to a meal."

Zhou Yi'an said with her mouth: "Do I need a meal from you?"

But her feet moved quickly. She grabbed the railing and jumped over directly, then the moment the man tried to close the door, she kicked him flying to the ground.

Zhou Yi'an jumped over, pinned his arm behind his back, and pressed her knee against his back. Seeing his fingers curling non-stop, she directly dislocated his wrist.

A very crisp sound of bones.

Even Lu Jiayi gasped.

But she looked at Liang Shi and chuckled lightly: "This friend of yours is quite interesting."

Liang Shi pursed her lips. Although somewhat reluctant, she still thanked her politely: "Thank you."

Lu Jiayi said: "It's nothing. Consider it... making a friend."

Liang Shi: "..."

Footnotes:

¹ Surrounded by wolves and tigers (身邊環狼虎伺): An idiom meaning to be surrounded by dangerous and ruthless people or competitors, implying that Lu Jiayi grew up in a cutthroat environment where she had to be vigilant against threats from all sides.

² Returned intact (完璧歸趙): A Chinese idiom literally meaning "returning the jade intact to the state of Zhao." It comes from a famous historical story and is used to describe returning something (or someone) to its rightful owner in perfect condition.

Chapter 154-7

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This night was full of one incident after another.

Liang Shi took Xu Qingzhu to the hospital for a checkup first, and only went home after confirming nothing was wrong.

By the time they got home, it was almost one in the morning.

She sent messages to everyone to let them know they were safe, and only then did she sit on the edge of the bed to rest.

Setting aside the original female lead's filter, Lu Jiayi was actually a very good person.

Knowing that Xu Qingzhu was married, she hadn't made any inappropriate moves toward Xu Qingzhu.

But everything she did was invisibly building goodwill.

And in front of her, Liang Shi was always one step behind.

This was the powerful influence of the plot.

But if she calmed down and carefully analyzed the logic of tonight's events.

Almost all the causes were different from before.

In the original plotline, Xu Qingzhu went to attend the banquet, accidentally stepped on her dress and tripped, falling into the water. Lu Jiayi happened to be socializing by the swimming pool, so she saved her.

After saving her, the two chatted for a while and eventually exchanged contact information.

That was their first meeting.

But tonight's situation was: because of Liang Shi's presence, Qin Lishuang noticed Xu Qingzhu, then drugged Xu Qingzhu, causing Xu Qingzhu—who could swim—to nearly drown in the water. And because Liang Shi was far away, Lu Jiayi still got there first.

The original owner couldn't swim, but she could.

Yet at the time, she had also nearly drowned in the water. This was probably the effect of the world's laws correcting themselves.

In other words, even if all the preconditions changed, the major events would still occur.

The system had reminded her of this issue back then—under the butterfly effect, all the minor details could be altered, but major events were bound to happen.

Unstoppably, unavoidably bound to happen.

This was the law by which this world operated.

Liang Shi suddenly felt a deep sense of powerlessness.

This meant she and Xu Qingzhu were definitely going to divorce. Even if she avoided the original turning points, the original timeline, and disrupted the original plans, they would still divorce.

If they didn't divorce, the harm would be transferred to her, herself, and Lu Jiayi—the three of them would randomly bear the harm, just like the incident with Chen Liuying before.

Until the harm satisfied the balance laws applicable to all planar worlds.

Once that balance point was reached, then this event wouldn't need to fully occur.

Liang Shi lay beside Xu Qingzhu, raising her hand to carefully trace over her brows and eyes.

Her fingers fell on the bridge of her nose, then she slowly leaned down and placed a kiss on her lips.

She kept thinking, let's try again.

Maybe there would be a turning point.

Liang Shi held her tight and closed her aching eyes.

Chapter 154-8

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When she woke up the next day, Xu Qingzhu felt her head was heavy and stuffy, as if someone had hit the back of her head with a club.

Sunlight fell into the room through the gaps in the curtains. When she opened her eyes, she saw Liang Shi.

Liang Shi was sleeping quietly. Though seemingly at her side, she had kept a slight distance, afraid of disturbing her sleep.

Actually, she had just had another nightmare—not the previous one, but still quite a terrifying dream.

It had nothing to do with Liang Shi, but it still scared her heart into palpitations.

But upon waking and seeing Liang Shi, she suddenly smiled, wanting very much to snuggle up against her.

Xu Qingzhu felt her throat was terribly dry, as if her whole body was about to catch fire.

She wanted to get out of bed quietly, but the moment she moved, Liang Shi opened her eyes, her voice carrying the hoarseness of just waking up: "You're awake?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "Mm."

No longer avoiding it, she directly snuggled into Liang Shi's arms, burying her head in the crook of her neck. "I made you worry last night. I'm sorry."

Liang Shi gently stroked her back. "Does your head hurt?"

"No." Xu Qingzhu coughed lightly. "I want to drink water."

Liang Shi released the fingers that were entwined in her hair. "I'll go pour some for you."

After saying that, she got up.

Xu Qingzhu lay there watching her back, then also got up and casually grabbed a piece of clothing from the closet to change into.

What she casually grabbed was Liang Shi's shirt.

It just barely covered her bottom.

After tossing her clothes into the laundry basket, Xu Qingzhu left the room. Liang Shi was standing in the kitchen pouring honey for her.

Xu Qingzhu walked over and hugged her from behind. She clearly felt Liang Shi's back stiffen, then she asked gently: "Why didn't you keep lying down?"

"I've been lying down all night." Xu Qingzhu said, "My back hurts."

"Alright then." Liang Shi said as she stirred the glass of water.

Xu Qingzhu asked: "How did you guys handle things last night? What about Qin Lishuang?"

Liang Shi paused for a moment. "We beat her up, then had Zhao Xuning record a video of her with a bruised and swollen face."

Xu Qingzhu: "...Why does it feel like middle schoolers fighting?"

"There was no other way." Liang Shi said, "She's despicable and base. We couldn't bring this matter out into the open, so we could only deal with her in secret."

At the time, Xu Qingzhu was still in a passive state, so they really couldn't do anything to Qin Lishuang.

After all, it was the Qin family's banquet.

However, Liang Shi had Zhao Xuning notify Qin Liushuang about this matter. If Qin Liushuang was a sensible person, she should know what to do.

At the very least, she couldn't let Qin Lishuang continue acting so recklessly.

The Qin family was powerful, but if several families joined forces, the Qin family would also be in danger.

Qin Liushuang needed to tighten up.

Liang Shi had also rarely asked her eldest brother for help, borrowing his authority to intimidate Qin Liushuang.

As for the rest, Zhou Yi'an had directly beaten people up.

Zhao Xuning had also stepped up to help.

To Qin Liushuang, this was tacit understanding that these people would all become the Qin family's enemies.

If it were just one family, Qin Liushuang could still shield Qin Lishuang. But with so many families at once... as long as Qin Liushuang wasn't stupid, she would definitely force Qin Lishuang to come out and apologize.

They just needed to sit and wait for the results.

Then Xu Qingzhu suddenly asked: "Did she ask you to be her model before?"

After saying that, she paused and corrected herself: "That person."

"Mm." Liang Shi said, "When she paints people, it's very disgusting."

Xu Qingzhu's arms tightened. Even Liang Shi's abs tensed up. With laughter in her voice, she said: "Baby, you're hugging too tight."

Xu Qingzhu rubbed her head against her back: "I'm comforting you."

Liang Shi: "..."

When the two were together, they seemed much more intimate than when separated by a camera lens.

Even those barriers had dissolved.

It seemed Xu Qingzhu wasn't having nightmares anymore, nor did she feel immense mental pressure from those events. She had simply stripped away to her most authentic self through those experiences.

Liang Shi finished preparing the water for her, scooped some with a spoon to test the temperature, and only turned around once it wasn't too hot.

But she froze when she saw her attire.

No bra, the shirt buttons fastened haphazardly—clearly dressed in a hurry.

The collar was wide open, with one button at the very top left undone, clearly revealing her collarbones.

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Liang Shi handed over the glass still steaming with water vapor. "Why are you wearing my shirt?"

Xu Qingzhu didn't take it. Instead, she held onto Liang Shi's hand and leaned in to drink a few sips. "Can't I?"

After drinking the honey water, even her throat seemed to be soaked with sweetness.

Liang Shi was helpless. "You can."

Xu Qingzhu finished the entire glass before she felt a bit better. Then Liang Shi poured herself a glass of warm water using another cup.

The water was very plain.

While she was drinking, Xu Qingzhu's head kept rubbing back and forth against her back.

Like a cat.

Liang Shi quickly finished drinking and asked her: "What's wrong?"

"Nothing." Xu Qingzhu said, "Do you have anything going on today?"

Liang Shi: "Technically, yes."

Xu Qingzhu asked: "In the afternoon?"

Liang Shi nodded: "I need to be at the set around three."

"Alright." Xu Qingzhu hugged her. "Then can I visit the set?"

"You can... it's just that if you're there, I might not be able to act well?" Liang Shi's tone was somewhat uncertain.

Xu Qingzhu asked: "Why?"

"The actress I have scenes with." Liang Shi said, "She's not as good-looking as you."

It clearly sounded like a line to coax someone, yet Liang Shi said it with utmost sincerity.

Xu Qingzhu was amused by her.

After laughing enough, Xu Qingzhu said softly: "Teacher Liang, lower your head."

Liang Shi was startled. "Why..."

While speaking, she lowered her head as told, but before she could finish her words, they were all swallowed up.

The word "why" got stuck in her throat.

It didn't need to be said at all.

Xu Qingzhu bit her lips. After drinking the honey water, her lips were also tinged with sweetness.

Xu Qingzhu asked her indistinctly: "Is it sweet?"

Liang Shi was flustered by her teasing, her ears turning red as she said: "It's sweet."

Her voice was very soft.

Downstairs, the endless flow of traffic continued. The water under Yujiang Bridge hadn't stopped flowing just because it was winter.

A thin layer of ice had formed on the river surface, but with the sunlight refracting off the ice, you could still see the water flowing beneath.

Xu Qingzhu's foot rested on the top of Liang Shi's foot, drawing closer when kissing her.

Neither needed to speak; they both understood each other's meaning.

The curtains in the room hadn't been drawn open yet, with only a sliver of sunlight penetrating through the gaps.

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu made their way from the living room to the bedroom.

When Liang Shi leaned down over her, she asked Xu Qingzhu: "Did you have nightmares last night?"

Xu Qingzhu's gaze paused for a moment, then she smiled: "Maybe because I slept in your arms, I had sweet dreams last night."

Liang Shi chuckled softly: "I have that effect?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded with great sincerity: "Yes."

"As long as you're by my side." Xu Qingzhu said, "They're all sweet dreams."

The last two words changed their tone within Liang Shi's kiss.

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It was an exhilarating feast.

Again and again, like the cicadas that never stopped chirping at the end of summer, as if knowing their time was near, they kept making sounds, wanting the world to remember their existence.

Xu Qingzhu was teased until she cried.

Even when not in an Omega's heat period, being intimate with one's marked partner would still bring tears.

So all her tears were kissed away by Liang Shi, swallowed, and then she was engulfed in great waves.

Xu Qingzhu's fingers fell on her shoulder blades, but afraid of hurting her, she only used her fingernails, not leaving any scratch marks on her beautiful back.

She had wanted to be naughty and leave strawberry marks on her neck, but considering she still had to film, she didn't go too far.

But after getting Liang Shi's permission, she left one strawberry mark after another over her heart.

Liang Shi indulged her with helpless affection.

Indulging her way of seeking security, enjoying her closeness and dependence.

She cried out: "Wife, hold me."

So after it ended, Liang Shi held her tight and carried her to take a bath.

Gentle water flowed past their bodies. Xu Qingzhu went completely limp against Liang Shi.

She pinched her ear in the water, then told her accompanied by the sound of water: "I love you so much, wife."

But Liang Shi didn't dare to say those words back.

Eventually, Xu Qingzhu noticed something was off and asked her softly: "Do you not love me anymore?"

So after bathing and returning to bed, Xu Qingzhu teased her once again.

Liang Shi's sweat fell on Xu Qingzhu's shoulder as she whispered in her ear: "Baby, I love you so much too."

The moment she finished saying those words, Liang Shi suddenly thought of a play she had watched many years ago.

The lyrics went like this: "Love knows not whence it came, yet once begun, it grows ever deeper."¹

The singing was melodious and lingering.

Most people only knew this line, not knowing that it was followed by: "The living may die for it, and the dead may live again. If the living cannot die for love, or the dead cannot be reborn for it, then it is not love at its truest."²

Back then, when Liang Shi saw "not love at its truest," she had only sighed—how could there be so much "truest love" in the world?

Now that she understood the taste of love, she could only sigh as well.

What a "not love at its truest."

When love reached its truest... then what?

For many, there was no "then what" at all.

Footnotes:

¹ "Love knows not whence it came, yet once begun, it grows ever deeper" (情不知所起，一往而深): This famous line is from "The Peony Pavilion" (牡丹亭), a renowned Chinese opera written by Tang Xianzu during the Ming Dynasty (1598). It describes how love arises inexplicably and becomes increasingly profound.

² "The living may die for it, and the dead may live again. If the living cannot die for love, or the dead cannot be reborn for it, then it is not love at its truest" (生者可以死，死可以生。生而不可與死，死而不可復生者，皆非情之至也): This is the continuation of the previous line from "The Peony Pavilion," expressing the ultimate devotion of true love—that one would die for it, and that such love has the power to transcend death itself. The opera tells the story of a woman who dies of lovesickness and is later resurrected through the power of love.

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This absurd affair with Xu Qingzhu lasted until two in the afternoon.

The two got up, took a shower, then went downstairs hand in hand to have lunch.

Xu Qingzhu didn't want to go to the company, so she willfully followed Liang Shi to the set. But she still brought her laptop.

She couldn't quite manage to be completely carefree after all.

In Xu Qingzhu's words of justification: "When you're being all lovey-dovey with the actress later, what am I supposed to do? I need to find something to keep myself busy. Work is the best way to numb oneself."

"But you and Sun Chengcheng—no matter how I look at it, she's no match for you?" Xu Qingzhu suddenly changed the topic. "How did you get schemed against by her back then?"

Liang Shi pressed her lips together and didn't answer.

Xu Qingzhu said: "Were you led astray by her beauty?"

Liang Shi: "...No."

"I think so too." Xu Qingzhu continued on her own: "You could even abandon me to go film. There's no way you'd show her any more consideration."

Liang Shi: "..."

"How did I abandon you?" Liang Shi argued. "Didn't I bring you to the set?"

Xu Qingzhu clicked her tongue, her eyes full of charm as they moved: "Then when I was trying to keep you in bed, didn't you also refuse?"

Liang Shi: "..."

"Are you sure you're still okay?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu coughed lightly: "You're the one who's not okay. Are your hands sore? Can you still drive?"

The question was asked suggestively.

Liang Shi's ears had already turned red, but they were hidden by her hair, so it wasn't clearly visible.

Xu Qingzhu became even more brazen. "How did you fall for her back then anyway? She's not as good-looking as me, and not as obedient either."

Liang Shi: "...I didn't fall for her. She was the one who came to curry favor with me. I just treated her like a little sister."

"Huh?" Xu Qingzhu shook her head. "Tsk."

Her tone was strange.

Liang Shi's hand rested on the steering wheel. "What are you doing? You're not going to be like this when we get to the set, are you?"

Xu Qingzhu: "How could I? I'll save face for you."

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Shi's face was written all over with "I don't believe you."

Then she heard Xu Qingzhu say: "But, my dear jiejie, just how many little sisters do you have?"

Liang Shi: "..."

"Are you there to film? Or to collect little sisters?" Xu Qingzhu said, "Be more well-behaved in the future, okay? Although I can understand others developing feelings through acting, but for you... I don't understand."

Liang Shi didn't know which question to answer for a moment, so she asked back: "Why?"

Xu Qingzhu paused for a moment, then said very seriously: "I have money, I'm beautiful, I'm sweet and obedient, and also... I love you so much."

Xu Qingzhu was a bit embarrassed saying this, but it was more like she was convincing herself to love Liang Shi well, so she looked at her seriously: "What reason would you have to develop feelings for someone else through acting?"

"If you develop feelings for someone else through acting, then from now on you'll only film with me." Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together. "I'll invest and transfer money to you. You're not allowed to like them."

These words were domineering and unreasonable, but coming from Xu Qingzhu, they seemed extremely adorable.

Liang Shi felt as if her heart was filled with something, sour and astringent, yet also ticklish.

They happened to be waiting at a very long red light. Liang Shi reached out and took Xu Qingzhu's hand, giving her fingers a squeeze. "Liking only you is enough for me."

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "I think so too, because I'm better than all of them."

"Then do you think I'm not good enough?" Liang Shi asked her. "Why do you love me? I don't seem to have any good qualities."

Xu Qingzhu paused.

This silence made Liang Shi somewhat nervous.

After a brief moment of thought, Xu Qingzhu looked at her very seriously. "Liang Shi, do you know?"

Liang Shi: "Hm?"

"In my eyes." Xu Qingzhu said, "You're shining all over."